

Stack B: Bodyguard Rule Fix

Version: 2026-04-25. Based on baseline rules v2026-04-25.

Feedback form (fill out after the game): [stack-b-feedback.pdf](#)

One change from baseline. Only the Bodyguard Rule adjacency requirement is different. Independent of Stack A — run any time. Carry all accepted changes (Layer 1 economy) forward.

Designer notes — read before facilitating, players can skip.

What we're testing: Does loosening the Bodyguard adjacency requirement to “adjacent to defender only” make the rule actually trigger and Guards genuinely useful?

Hypothesis: “Adjacent to both attacker AND defender” was too restrictive. “Adjacent to defender only” makes Guard positioning much simpler and the rule much more likely to fire.

Watch for:

- Does the Bodyguard rule trigger? How many times per game?
- Do players actively position Guards to protect Champions/King?
- Does it feel too easy to bodyguard? Is a 1-Guard wall impenetrable?
- Do Guards survive longer or die faster?

All rules below are current baseline. The only changed section is marked ⚡.

Goal

Capture the opponent's **King**. The game ends immediately when a King is removed from the board.

Draw conditions:

- No piece has been captured for 10 consecutive full rounds.
- Only the two Kings remain on the board.

Components

Per player: 1 King · 5 Champions · 6 Guards

Shared (Prototype): 10x10 grid board · Skill cards · Injured markers · Armor pieces

Skill Drafting

- Lay out all available skills face-up as a shared pool.
- Alternating draft: P1 picks 2 skills from the pool and assigns them freely to any of their Champions or King → P2 picks 2 skills and assigns freely → repeat.
- Continue until all 5 Champions and the King on each side have 2 skills.
- Both players draft from the same pool. Duplicates are allowed.

Setup

- **Board:** Use the 10x10 grid.
- **First player:** Flip a coin (or decide verbally).
- **Piece placement:** Each player places pieces on their own back two rows:
 - Back row (row 1/10): King in the centre, Champions fill the remaining 5 spaces.
 - Second row (row 2/9): All 6 Guards.
- **Skill Draft:** Alternating picks. P1 picks 2 skills from the pool and assigns them freely to any of their Champions or King, then P2. Repeat until all Champions and the King on each side have 2 skills each (12 per player). Duplicates allowed.
- **Starting Runes:** Each player starts with **6 Runes**.
- P1 begins Round 1.

Round Structure

A **Round** = P1's Turn + P2's Turn.

At the **start of each player's turn** (before they do anything), that player collects their Rune income. (*Exception: Round 1 — players begin with their starting Runes and collect nothing before their first turn.*)

Turn Structure

Each **Turn** has two phases, in order:

- **Movement Phase** — spend Move Slots to move pieces (and attack).
- **Action Phase** — spend Skill Slots to activate skills.

You may use 0 slots in either phase.

Movement Phase

You have **2 Move Slots** per turn. Spend 1 Move Slot to move one piece — either **into empty space** (normal movement) or **into an enemy tile** (a Standard Attack — see next section). **Each piece may only be moved once per Movement Phase.**

Piece	Normal speed	Injured speed
Guard	2 tiles	1 tile
Champion / King	1 tile	1 tile

Free pathing: A piece may move in any direction — horizontal, vertical, diagonal — taking any route up to its speed in tiles. The route does not have to be a straight line.

Pieces block movement: A moving piece cannot pass through any other piece, ally or opponent.

- *Exception:* A piece may go around a blocking piece if total tiles moved stays within speed (e.g. a Guard using 2 diagonal moves to go around a piece directly in the way).
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Standard Attack

A **Standard Attack** is a Move that ends on an enemy tile. Spend 1 Move Slot to move your piece **onto a tile occupied by an enemy piece.**

- Deal **1 DMG** to the enemy.
- **If the enemy is removed:** your piece occupies the tile (the attack consumed the move; remaining unused movement tiles do not carry over).
- **If the enemy survives** (Armor absorbed the damage): your piece **stops on the tile immediately before the target.** This applies to **every** attacker — a Guard with speed 2 ends up having moved only 1 tile; a Champion or King with speed 1 does not move at all. Either way the damage is dealt. (*If multiple paths reach the target, you choose which one — important for the Bodyguard Rule.*)

You may attack with one Move Slot and move a different piece with the other Move Slot in the same turn.

Standard Attacks are how pieces deal damage with movement alone. Skills — activated in the Action Phase — are the other way pieces affect each other, and use different rules (Skill Path, Range, Runes).

Action Phase

You have **2 Skill Slots** per turn (at the start (see Progression)).

Spend 1 Skill Slot to activate one equipped skill on one of your Champions or King:

- Announce the skill and the target.
- Pay the skill's Rune cost.
- Apply the skill's effect.

The same Champion can activate multiple skills (also the same one) in one turn if you have Skill Slots remaining.

Skill System

Skill Path: Skills travel in a **straight line** (horizontal, vertical, or diagonal) from the caster, like a chess Queen.

Blocking: The Skill Path is blocked by **all pieces** — ally and opponent alike. The skill cannot reach past the first piece in its path.

Range: The distance in tiles along the Skill Path from caster to target. Range is measured as:

- Range 0 = self (caster's own tile)
- Range 1 = adjacent tile along Skill Path
- Range 2 = 2 tiles away along Skill Path (etc.)

Default Range = 2. Unless a skill explicitly names “self” or “adjacent” in its effect text. A skill with a Range modifier (e.g. “Range –1”) is still a Range 2 skill with a modifier applied — it is not treated as adjacent or self.

Self vs. adjacent: “Self” skills (Range 0) target only the caster — they cannot target adjacent pieces, even with a Range buff. “Adjacent” skills (Range 1) target only neighbouring pieces — they cannot target the caster, even with a Range buff. Range buffs (e.g. Focus Strike) shift the targeting window outward; they do not collapse it inward.

Injured Range penalty: Injured pieces have Skill Range –1. Skills that explicitly name “self” or “adjacent” in their text are unaffected — they always work regardless of Injured status.

Skills that move pieces do not deal damage. Movement-via-skill (Quick Dash, Shadow Shift, Retreat Plan) does not count as a Standard Attack and deals no damage on arrival - you are instead stopped from moving the piece further in that direction.

A Champion may use its skills multiple times in the same turn if Skill Slots are available — including the same skill twice.

All skills cost 1 Skill Slot unless noted otherwise.

Resource Economy (Runes)

Starting Runes: 6 per player.

Rune income is collected at the **start of each player's own turn:**

Round	Income per player turn
1	0 (starting Runes only)
2-4	+2
5-9	+3
10-14	+4
15+	+5 (+1 every 5 rounds)

No Rune cap.

Progression

Round	Skill Slots per turn
1-10	2
11-20	3
21-30	4
31+	5 (+1 every 10 rounds)

Health & Armor

All pieces have 2 HP: Normal → Injured → Removed.

State	HP	Effect
Normal	2	No penalty
Injured	1	Speed capped at 1. Skill Range -1 (affects Range 2+ only).
Removed	0	Piece leaves the board permanently.

Damage:

- 1 DMG to Normal → Injured.
- 1 DMG to Injured → Removed.
- 2 DMG to Normal → Removed instantly (Injured state is skipped).

Armor: Max 3 points per piece. Each absorbs 1 DMG, then destroyed. Resolves before HP damage. **Does not prevent Injured status.**

⚡ CHANGED: Bodyguard Rule

	Baseline	This Layer
Guard must be adjacent to	Both tile-before-target AND defender	Defender only
Everything else	—	Unchanged

When you make a **Standard Attack** against an opponent's Champion or King, the defender may choose to have a Guard intercept — **if** a friendly Guard is on a tile **adjacent to the defending piece** (*baseline requires adjacent to both the tile immediately before the target AND the defending piece*).

Interception:

1. Defender announces a Guard to intercept.
2. The Guard takes the damage instead of the original target.
3. The attacker moves **1 tile** toward the target (stops on the tile immediately before the Guard, not before the original target).

Interception is optional. The defender may decline even if a Guard is eligible.

Only Standard Attacks can be intercepted. Skills always hit directly.

Example:

```
. . . . .
. G . . .
. . C . .   C = your Champion, G = your Guard, A = enemy piece
. . . A .
. . . . .
```

Enemy A attacks Champion C. Your Guard G is adjacent to C (but not to A). Under baseline this would not qualify — under this layer it does. You intercept: A moves 1 tile toward C, G takes the damage, C is safe.

Skill Drafting

- Lay out all available skills face-up as a shared pool.
- Alternating draft: P1 picks 2 skills from the pool and assigns them freely to any of their Champions or King → P2 picks 2 skills and assigns freely → repeat.
- Continue until all 5 Champions and the King on each side have 2 skills.
- Both players draft from the same pool. Duplicates are allowed.

Skill Reference

	Cat.	Name	Cost	Effect
	Strike	Lance Thrust	2	Target within Range-1 takes 1 DMG
	Strike	Hook Pull	3	Target takes 1 DMG, pulled 1 tile toward caster along Skill Path
	Strike	Armor Breaker	2	Remove 1 Armor from target. <i>(Note: does not deal "HP-Damage" unless boosted by Blade Call)</i>
	Strike	Rune Theft	3	Target takes 1 DMG. Steal 1 Rune from opponent.
	Strike	Blade Tempest	4	Target takes 1 DMG. All pieces adjacent to the target are pushed 1 tile away from the target. The attacker/caster is not affected.
	Shield	Rust Shield	2	Self: gain +1 Armor
	Shield	Field Medic	3	Remove Injured from one adjacent ally
	Shield	Armorsmith	3	Adjacent ally gains +1 Armor
	Move	Quick Dash	3	Self: move up to 2 tiles along Skill Path
	Move	Air Blast	2	Push target enemy 1 tile directly away from caster
	Move	Precision Thrust	3	Push target enemy 1 tile in any direction (caster chooses). Range+1.
	Move	Shadow Shift	4	Swap position with an allied piece. Requires unobstructed Skill Path.
	Move	Retreat Plan	4	Self: move along Skill Path to land adjacent to one of your Guards. Range+1.
	Mystic	Focus Strike	1	The next skill used by any of your pieces this turn gains +1 Range. <i>(Note: can boost self and adjacent skills — Range 0 → 1, Range 1 → 2.)</i> Move skills: the caster chooses, when activating the Move skill, whether the +1 applies to its activation range (how far the skill can target) or its effect range (how far it moves/pushes). Not both.
	Mystic	Blade Call	3	One Strike skill used by any of your pieces this turn deals +1 DMG.

Quick Reference

Concept	Rule
Movement	Free pathing, ≤ speed in tiles, cannot pass through pieces. Each piece once per phase.
Attack	Move onto enemy tile (1 Move Slot). 1 DMG.
Attack — target survives	Attacker stops on tile before target
Skill Path	Straight line (Queen). Blocked by all pieces.
Default Skill Range	Range 2 (unless skill specifies)
Bodyguard ⚡	Guard adjacent to defender only . Guard takes the damage. Attacker moves 1 tile. Standard Attacks only. Optional.
Rune income	Start of YOUR turn (not Round 1). 6 start, +2/+3/+4/+5 scaling.
Healing	No cap. Same piece can be healed multiple times per turn.
Armor	Armor absorbs damage first, then HP